Minxuan (Martin) Cao

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Education

B.S. in Psychology; Minor in Education, Learning & Society Sep 2024–Present
University of Washington *Seattle, WA*

- GPA: 3.88/4.00; Psychology Honors Program; Dean's List, 2024–2026.

Research and Design Interests: Human factors, human–AI interaction, embodied interaction, UX research, behavioral product design, and responsible AI.

Selected Human-Centered Design Projects

Waiting With You 2026–Present
Independent Product Designer and Developer | Python, Streamlit, user journey mapping

- Mapped candidate and recruiter journeys for an AI-assisted hiring platform, identifying application silence and ambiguous status information as consequential parts of the candidate experience.
- Reframed a recruiter-centered concept into a two-sided workflow and built a runnable prototype with candidate and recruiter views, staged status explanations, supportive messaging, and refresh tracking; AI responses and email delivery remain simulated.

IP Alive 2026–Present
Independent Human–AI Product Researcher, Designer, and Developer | React Native, Expo, TypeScript

- Collected 165 exploratory survey responses, including 150 valid responses, to examine how owners' sense of connection to physical character collectibles may change after purchase; translated findings into design hypotheses and product requirements.
- Built a high-fidelity interactive prototype for persistent character engagement through conversation, memory, events, travel, customization, and games; defined boundaries for privacy, attachment, user-controlled memory, character governance, and monetization. Production AI, persistent storage, and payment services are not connected.

Pause With You 2026
Independent Human Factors Researcher and Physical Product Designer | Focused review, task decomposition, safety analysis

- Conducted a design-oriented focused review of smoking-related pharmacological, sensorimotor, visual, ritual, and contextual functions, treating lived experience as a starting observation rather than evidence of general effectiveness.
- Decomposed smoking into a 12-step interaction sequence and derived requirements for a non-combustion, nicotine-free physical concept that avoids inhalation through the device; separated user-air, water, and control pathways and defined fail-safe and staged validation requirements without making safety or cessation claims.

Holding Together 2026
Independent HCI Researcher and Physical Interaction Designer

- Synthesized 25 sources on loneliness, social touch, and AI companionship into a critical review and design requirements for a home embracing device.
- Developed form and material concepts, a staged evaluation plan, and an offline demo with separate partner voice and touch permissions; hardware and live calling remain unvalidated.

Research Experience

Psychology Honors Program Dec 2025–Present
Department of Psychology, University of Washington *Seattle, WA*

- Developed a study examining whether four structured, ACL-inspired dyadic conversations can support people experiencing uncertainty while awaiting employment, internship, or further-education decisions.
- Prepared the proposal and pre-data-collection materials, including participant eligibility, outcome measures, recruitment procedures, session structure, and staff training.

Research Assistant Sep 2025–Present
Center for the Science of Social Connection, University of Washington *Seattle, WA*

- Contributed to experiential protocol testing, participant recruitment, session-data preparation, transcript cleaning, descriptive analysis, and tables and figures for a four-session trauma-informed ACL pilot; fourth author on the published article.
- Completed approximately 100 hours of FAP/ACL training under Mavis Tsai, Ph.D., focused on behavioral observation and present-moment interpersonal processes; supported recruitment, onboarding, and training of new laboratory members.

Research Assistant Jul 2025–Sep 2025
Yang Lab, Beijing Normal University *Beijing, China*

- Supported participant-facing fNIRS and behavioral research with students in Grades 2–5 experiencing reading and attention-related challenges.
- Prepared study sessions, administered supervised behavioral measures, and supported pre/post data processing while monitoring instruction clarity, fatigue, comfort, and equipment setup.

Product and User Experience

Product Support and Psychology Intern Jun 2026–Sep 2026
Changsha Hongjun Technology Co., Ltd. *Changsha, China / Remote*

- Annotated and quality-checked multimodal AI data using facial action units and behavioral and psychological coding, translating interpretations into operational labels for product workflows.
- Supported psychological measurement, interface and visual design in JS Design, and audiovisual production using DaVinci Resolve and CapCut.

User Experience Specialist and Psychology Support Consultant Dec 2025–Present
Kemi Online Counseling Platform *Remote*

- Identified recurring usability issues through direct user interactions and reported product recommendations to the technical lead; applied FAP- and SFBT-informed listening in student mental-health and career-stress contexts.

Psychiatric Department Intern Mar 2024–Sep 2024
Changzhou De'an Hospital *Changzhou, China*

- Assisted under supervision with psychological scales and cognitive assessments and observed ward rounds, shift handoffs, and emergency clinical workflows.

Publications, Manuscripts, and Presentations

Mattingly, L. C., Figueroa, B., Barsy, A., **Cao, M.**, Mills, A., & Tsai, M. (2026). *From isolation to connection: A trauma-informed Awareness, Courage & Love pilot intervention for adults with adverse childhood experiences. Medical Research Archives, 14*(9). https://doi.org/10.18103/mra.2026.0537

Cao, M. (2023). An investigation of social factors contributing to unrealistic self-assessment. *International Journal of Education and Humanities, 10*(1), 178–180. doi:10.54097/ijeh.v10i1.11114

Oral Presentation on Eating Disorders and Body-Image Anxiety 2026
Online Academic Conference

- Delivered an oral presentation introducing three eating disorders, with particular emphasis on binge-eating disorder and anorexia nervosa; critically examined appearance anxiety and body-image anxiety.

Leadership

Director of Planning; Interim President Jun 2025–Jun 2026
HuaPsychology Club *Seattle, WA*

- Created the planning department's first SOP and leadership handbook, led other departments in documenting operations, organized a university-level new-student event, and recruited, trained, and mentored undergraduate members.

Skills and Training

Research: Experimental design, focused literature review, participant recruitment, exploratory surveys, behavioral coding, psychometrics, transcript preparation, data visualization, and fNIRS data collection.
Design: User journey mapping, task decomposition, interaction design, prototyping, requirements development, usability-test planning, and safety and ethics analysis.
Programming and Analysis: Python, R, MATLAB, SPSS, jamovi, Excel, and Git/GitHub.
Media: JS Design, DaVinci Resolve, and CapCut.
Relevant Training: Functional Analytic Psychotherapy, Solution-Focused Brief Therapy, and Acceptance and Commitment Therapy.
Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), English (TOEFL 108), and Cantonese Chinese (conversational).